THE BUILD TRAP · AI

AI didn’t kill the build trap.

It cut the brakes.

IDEA

Cheap building removes the last reason to choose.

01 / THE TRAP

Shipping isn’t success. Changed behavior is.

The build trap: measuring output (features shipped) instead of outcomes (value created).

WHAT YOU SHIP

OUTPUT

Features. Releases. Story points.

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WHAT CHANGES

OUTCOME

Customers act differently. The business grows.

02 / SYMPTOMS

You’re in the trap if:

- [x] Your roadmap is features with dates.
- [x] Success means “how much we shipped.”
- [x] Nobody checks what happened after launch.

03 / WHY IT PERSISTS

Organizations reward what they can count.

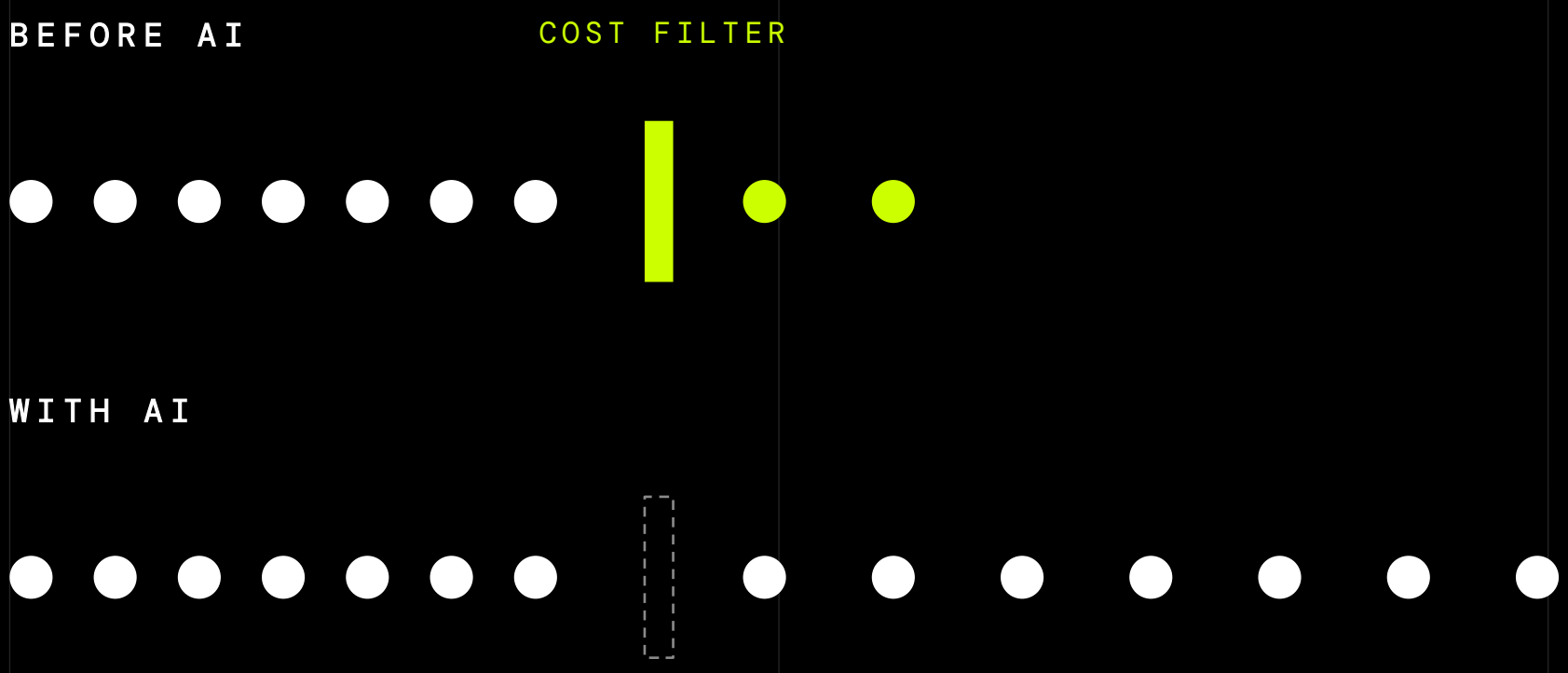
Output is visible and easy to praise. Outcomes are slow and messy. So the dashboard wins.



04 / THE AI TWIST

Cost used to be the brake. AI removed it.

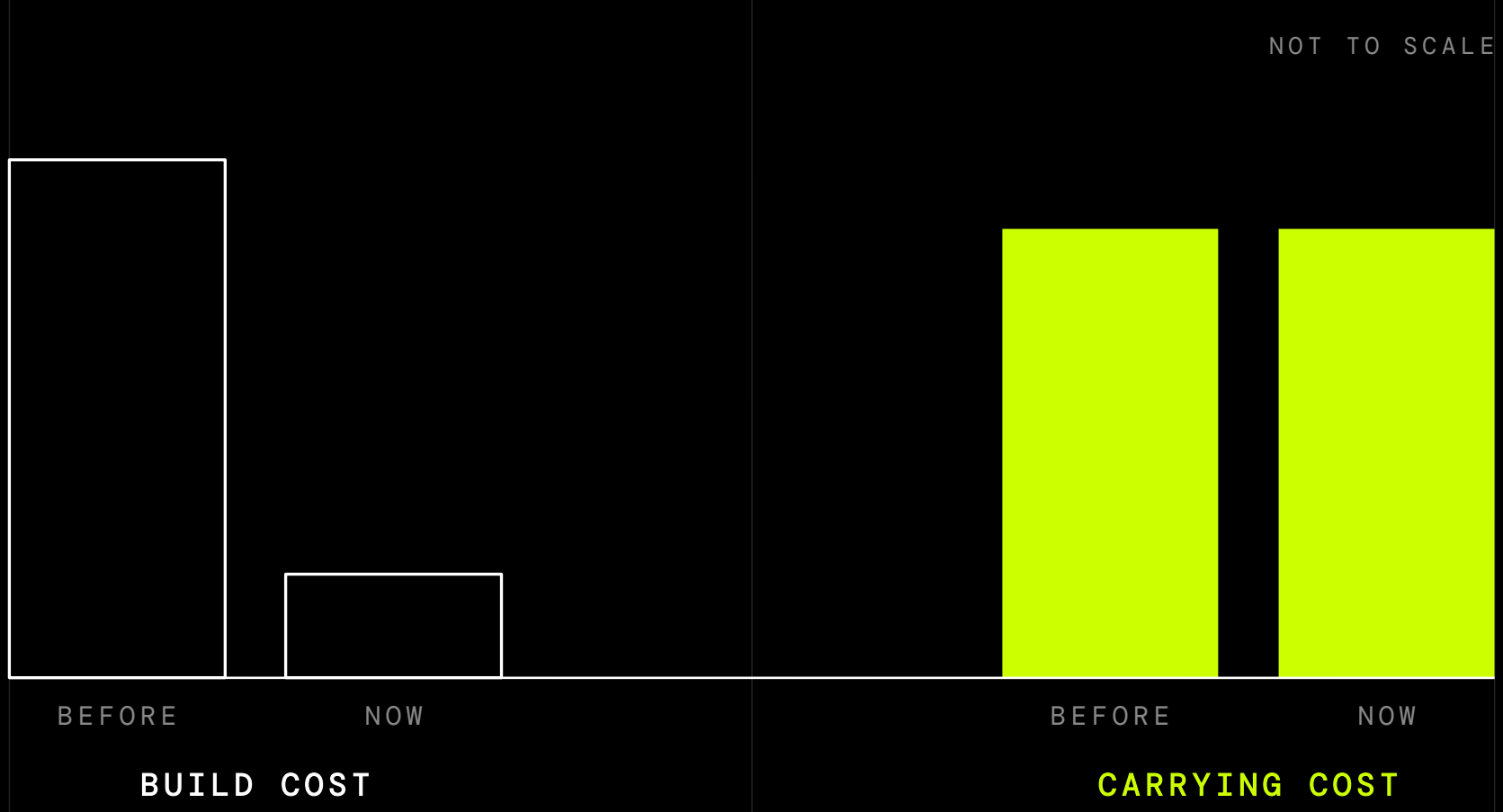
When building was expensive, cost forced a choice. Now nothing does.



05 / THE HIDDEN BILL

Build cost fell.
Carrying cost didn’t.

Every feature still adds maintenance, complexity, and one more thing users must learn.



06 / THE ESCAPE

A feature is a bet, not a result.

AFTER MELISSA PERRI, ESCAPING THE BUILD TRAP

01 Start from the outcome, not the feature.

02 PMs own the why, not just the when.

03 Ship as an experiment. Check what changed.

04 Kill what didn’t move the outcome.



When building is free, saying no is the product.